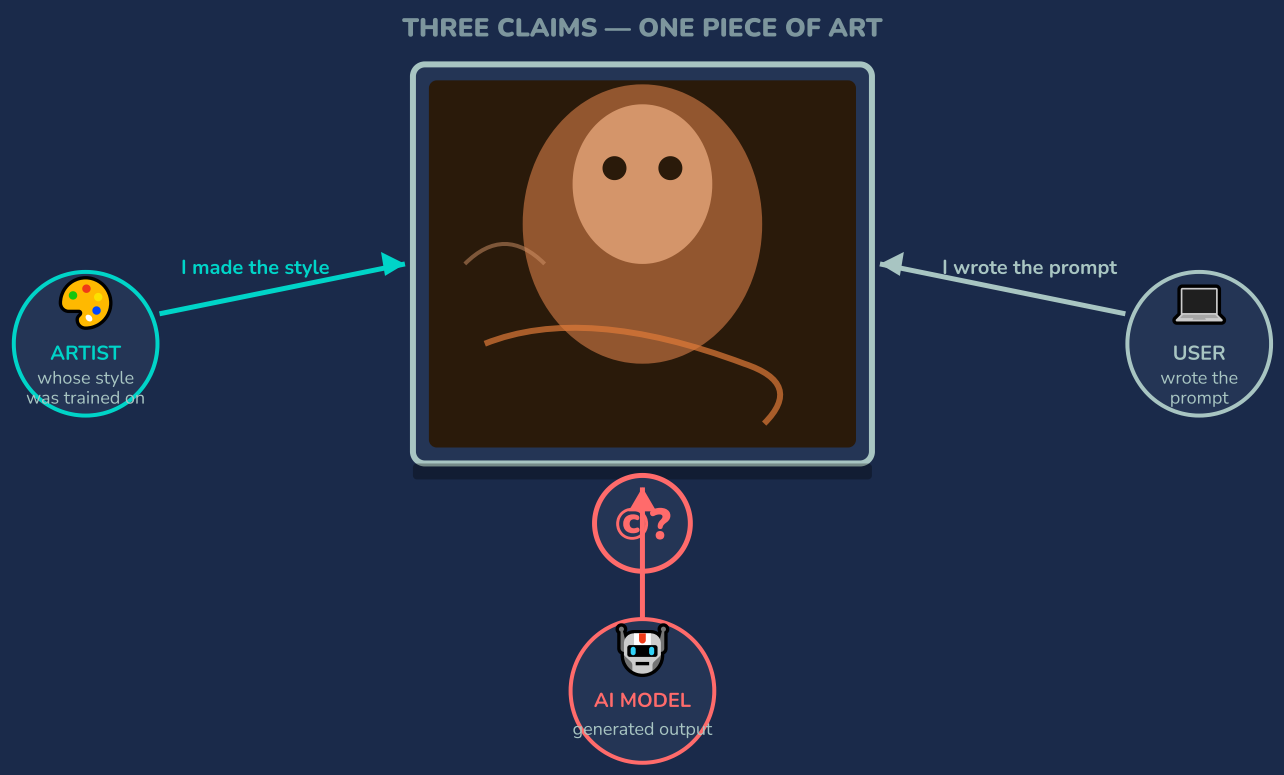
WHO OWNS AI ART?

If AI makes something, who created it — and who owns it?



ARGUE

JUDGE

DECIDE

WHO OWNS AI ART?

This is a live legal and ethical debate. Copyright law in most countries has not yet caught up with AI-generated content. Students should understand the competing claims before forming an opinion.

MAIN ACTIVITY

1. Show a piece of AI-generated art. Introduce three claimants: the artist whose style was used in training data, the AI model, and the user who wrote the prompt.
2. Groups form "legal teams" representing each claimant. Each has 5 minutes to build their case — what did their client contribute?
3. A mock tribunal (3 students as judges) hears the arguments and gives a verdict. Judges must explain their reasoning clearly.
4. Class votes on whether the verdict was fair. Discuss: who did they think deserved the credit — and does credit equal ownership?

MATERIALS

- Image of AI-generated art (printed)
- Claimant role cards (3 versions)
- Verdict template for judges
- Case preparation worksheet
- Voting slips for class vote

REFLECTION

- Does effort determine ownership? Does intention?
- What would it mean for human artists if AI art can be copyrighted?
- Should there be a separate legal category for AI-generated work?
- Can something be creative without a creator?

REALITY CHECK

In most countries, copyright currently requires a human author.

AI-generated works with no significant human creative input may not be legally protected — but this is actively being debated in courts and legislatures worldwide. The law is genuinely unsettled.

GO DEEPER

Ownership Simulator

Scan to play →

⏱ 55 MIN | MOCK TRIBUNAL | ADVANCED | CARD 19